Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, April-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at:
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
        v – enter select mode
        3 – select 3
        w – words
        d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
       wd – delete word
       xc – change line
       %y – yank entire file
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior functi
]t, [t – to next, prior type d
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comm
]g, [g – to next, prior chang
]G, [G – to last, first change
Alt-e – move to end of pare
Alt-b – move to start of par
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between ancho
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
     % – select whole file
Alt-; – swap anchor and cu
Alt-: – selection to normal
Alt-o – expand selection sy
Alt-i – shrink selection
     ; – collapse selection(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match arou
                  below:
       w / W – word / WO
           p – paragraph
(, [, ', etc.– specified su
           m – closest sur
           f – function
           t – type or clas
           a – argument/
           c – comment
           T – test
           g – change git
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
w / W – to start of next word
e / E – to end of current wo
b / B – to start of current w
    x – current line, extend
    X – extend to line
Alt-x – shrink to line bound
   ]p – to next paragraph
   [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree o
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
:  – command
i  – insert
v  – select or extend
z  – view - change view preserving selection
g  – goto
m  – match
Ctrl-w – window
␣  – space
[, ] – unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree history
:ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by step count or time span
              (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
<nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

```
:wq – write current buffer and quit
:wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
:wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
:q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
:o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
:w <file> – write current buffer to <file>

:hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
:vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.

␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
␣F – open file picker at current working directory
␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
<enter> – open selected in current view
Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
:n – create new scratch buffer
:bc – close current buffer
:bca – close all buffers
:bco – close all but current buffer
:bn – next buffer
␣b – open buffer picker

ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
gn – go to next buffer
gp – go to previous buffer
```

```
Alt-p – select previous sibli
Alt-n – select next sibling n
Alt-a – select all sibling nod
Alt-I – select all children no
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusiv
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusiv
Alt-.  – repeat last find
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
v – toggle select mode
Esc – return to normal
) – cycle primary select
( – cycle primary select
Alt-,  – remove primary sele
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
s<regex> – matches become sel
S – split on match
Alt-s – split on newlines
C, Alt-C – add selection below,
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
& – align on primary cu
Alt-<minus> – merge selections
Alt-<under> – merge consecutive s
,  – remove all except pr
Alt-,  – remove primary sele
( / ) – rotate primary back
Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content back
K – keep selections mat
Alt-K – remove selections m
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
i – before selection
a – after selection
I – at start of line
A – at end of line
o – add line and insert b
O – add line and insert a
Esc – end insert (return to
. – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
]␣ – newline below
[␣ – newline above
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> arou
```

2.6.3 Delete

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and ␣w are synonymous.

```
  ␣ws / ␣wv  – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
 ␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
        ␣wq – close current split
        ␣wo – close all but current split
        ␣ww – next split

  ␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
  ␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
        ␣wt – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
          Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc

     zz, zc – align to center
         zt – align to top
         zb – align to bottom
         zm – align to middle horizontally
         zj – scroll down
         zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
     :tutor – open tutorial
         ␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
     h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
      gh, g| – beginning of line
     <nn>g| – column <nn>
          gl – end of line
          gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
          ge – bottom of file
          gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to word

          g.– to last modification in current file
          gj – down textual line
          gk – up textual line

          gs – first non-white-space char
          gt – top of screen
          gc – middle of screen
          gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol - Semantics

Requires LSP support.

```
          gd – go to definition
          gy – go to type definition
          gr – go to references
          gi – go to implementation

          ]d – next diagnostic
          [d – prior diagnostic
          ]D – last diagnostic
          [D – first diagnostic
```

```
           d – selection -> yank buf
      Alt-d – delete, no save
    md<ch> – delete delim <ch> ar
```

2.6.4 Change

```
           c – selection -> yank buf
      Alt-c – change, no save
           = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
           > – Indent line(s) contai
           < – Undent line(s) conta
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
           ~ – change case
           ` – set lowercase
      Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
          ␣C – Toggle block comme
     ␣Alt-C – Toggle line commen
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
      Ctrl-a – increment the selec
      Ctrl-x – decrement the selec
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
           J – join lines in a selecti
      Alt-J – join lines inside sele
    <under> – trim whitespace fro
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
           y – selection -> yank buf
           p – paste yank buf after
           P – paste yank buf befor
          ␣y – yank selection(s) -> s
          ␣Y – yank main selection
  ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard afte
          ␣R – replace selection(s) w
     r<ch> – replace selection wi
           R – replace selection wi
           " – select register to ya
```

2.8 Search

```
   /<regex> – search forward for r
   ?<regex> – search backward for
       n, N – next, previous matc
          * – search for current s
      Alt-* – search for current s
```

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efinition

ent
e

nt node in syntax tree
ent node in syntax tree

or and cursor

rsor
direction (cursor at end)
ntax-aware

to cursor(s)

und / inside the object indicated by <ch>

RD

urround pairs
round pair

ss
parameter

hunk

d / WORD
ord / WORD
word / WORD
by line

ls

parent syntax node
bject selection

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
"<ch>  – change to reg <ch>
"<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
"<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
"<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
"<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
"<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
␣j     – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
mm          – go to matching delim
mi<ch>      – match inside delim <ch>
ma<ch>      – match around delim <ch>
ms<ch>      – add delim <ch> around selection
md<ch>      – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
|     – replace selection(s) with output
Alt-| – ignore output
!     – insert output before each selection(s)
Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
$     – keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
␣G – debug - experimental
␣k – show documentation for item under cursor
␣s – open document symbol picker
␣S – open workspace symbol picker
␣d – open document diagnostics picker
␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
␣r – rename symbol
␣a – apply code action
␣h – select symbol references for symbol under cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
:config-open           – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace config file
:config-reload         – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
␣' – open last picker
␣/ – open global search in workspace folder picker
```

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natching the regex

below cursor
above cursor
normal)

nd selection

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

`Ctrl-s`	commit undo checkpoint
`Ctrl-x`	autocomplete
`Ctrl-r`	insert a register content
`Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp>`	delete previous word
`Alt-d, Alt-<del>`	delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	delete to end of line
`Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp>`	delete previous char
`Ctrl-d, <del>`	delete next char
`Ctrl-j, <enter>`	insert new line
`<Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> <PageUp> <PageDown> <Home> <End>`	usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

`Esc, Ctrl-c`	close prompt
`<enter>`	open selected
`<tab>`	select next completion item
`<backtab>`	select previous completion item
`Alt-b`	backward a word
`Ctrl-b`	backward a char
`Alt-f`	forward a word
`Ctrl-f`	forward a char
`Ctrl-e`	to prompt end
`Ctrl-a`	to prompt start
`Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp>`	delete previous word
`Alt-d, Ctrl-<del>`	delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	delete to end of line
`<bksp>, Ctrl-h`	delete previous char
`<del>, Ctrl-d`	delete next char
`Ctrl-s`	insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
`Ctrl-p`	select previous history
`Ctrl-n`	select next history
`Ctrl-r`	insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

`Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up>`	previous entry
`<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down>`	next entry
`<Home>`	to first entry
`<End>`	to last entry
`Ctrl-u, <PageUp>`	page up
`Ctrl-d, <PageDown>`	page down
`<enter>`	open selected
`Alt-<enter>`	open selected in the background without closing the picker
`Ctrl-s`	open horizontally
`Ctrl-v`	open vertically
`Ctrl-t`	toggle preview
`Esc, Ctrl-c`	close picker

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

`Ctrl-u`	scroll up
`Ctrl-d`	scroll down

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

f, delete selection

ound selection

f, change selection

with <ch2>

ning selection
ining selection

ent
t

ted number
ted number

on
ction and select the inserted space
m selection

f
the cursor
e the cursor
system clipboard
-> system clipboard
r / before selections(s)
with clipboard
th <ch>
th yank buf
nk to or paste from

egex
r regex
h
election, respect word boundaries
election

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
      Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
        <enter> – close menu and accept completion
         Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
Alt-p – previous signature
Alt-n – next signature
```